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Students Studying in The United States

# J-1 STUDENT VISA PROCESS

Are you an international student participating in an exchange program with a government, organizational, or university sponsorship? If so, you may need to travel with a J-1 student visa.



## VISA INTERVIEW APPOINTMENTS MUST BE SCHEDULED IN COUNTRY OF RESIDENCE OR NATIONALITY

Effective September 6, 2025, all applicants for F/J nonimmigrant visas must schedule their visa interview appointment at a U.S. Embassy or Consulate in their country of nationality or

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residence.

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[Click Here to Read the Announcement \(https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/visa-interview](https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/visa-interview)

## ABOUT THE J-1 EXCHANGE VISITOR PROGRAM

The J-1 Exchange Visitor Program, also called “[BridgeUSA \(https://j1visa.state.gov/\)](https://j1visa.state.gov/),” was established by the Mutual Educational and Cultural Exchange Act of 1961 (The Fulbright-Hays Act) and is administered by the U.S. Department of State to increase mutual understanding between the people of the United States and the people of other countries by means of educational and cultural exchanges.

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We encourage all J-1 visa applicants to review the BridgeUSA website linked above, as well as the Department of State [Exchange Visitor Program Welcome Brochure \(https://j1visa.state.gov/wp-content/uploads/2022/05/EVP-Welcome-Brochure-2022.pdf\)](https://j1visa.state.gov/wp-content/uploads/2022/05/EVP-Welcome-Brochure-2022.pdf).

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## J-1 VISA ELIGIBILITY

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In order to qualify for a J-1 visa and be eligible to request a Form DS-2019 from Northeastern University, prospective J-1 visa applicants must:

- Be financed directly or indirectly by the U.S. government, the government of their home country, an international organization of which the United States is a member by treaty or statute, or supported substantially by funding from any source other than personal or family funds (**greater than 50% of your funding must be from non-personal or family sources**).

- > Participate in a program that has an agreement between the U.S. government and a foreign government, or according to a written agreement between Northeastern and foreign educational institutions, Northeastern and a foreign government or a state or local government in the United States and a foreign government.
- > Be able to demonstrate the required amount of funding for the **entire duration of your program** in order to be eligible for a DS-2019.

## REQUESTING A FORM DS-2019

**For incoming exchange students admitted to an exchange program through the Global Experience Office (GEO)**

**(<https://geo.northeastern.edu/programs/incoming-exchange-program/>)**, you will directly receive a link to request a DS-2019 from GEO after you are admitted to the exchange program.

**For other non-degree exchange programs at Northeastern**, your admissions contact will provide you with a link to request the DS-2019 after your admission.

**For admitted degree-seeking students:** If your source of funding for your degree program requires you to apply for a J-1 visa (such as a government scholarship) or you believe you otherwise qualify to apply for a J-1 visa for your degree program, please contact OGS via our [inquiry form](https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs?id=ogs_ask_a_question&sys_id=47cb95e387e1759011b72fc5dabb3512) ([https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs?id=ogs\\_ask\\_a\\_question&sys\\_id=47cb95e387e1759011b72fc5dabb3512](https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs?id=ogs_ask_a_question&sys_id=47cb95e387e1759011b72fc5dabb3512)) detailing your funding source. If it is determined you are eligible to apply for the J-1 visa, OGS will directly email you instructions to submit a DS-2019 request.

## APPLYING FOR A J-1 VISA

If Northeastern is sponsoring your J-1 visa, the Office of Global Services (OGS) will be in touch to process your DS-2019.

If Northeastern is not the organization sponsoring your visa (Fulbright or Science Without Borders, for example), then your exchange organization will prepare your DS-2019 and send it

to you. With the DS-2019, you may start the visa application process:

- Check your passport's validity. It must be valid for at least six months from the date you return to the U.S.
- Pay the [Student and Exchange Visitor Information System \(SEVIS\) fee](https://fmjfee.com/index.html) (<https://fmjfee.com/index.html>)
- Gather supporting documents for the visa interview (<https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/study/exchange.html#documentation>)
- Make an appointment at the [nearest U.S. Embassy or U.S. Consulate](http://www.usembassy.gov/index.html) (<http://www.usembassy.gov/index.html>) for a visa interview
  - The U.S. Department of State has [published estimated Global Visa Wait Times on their website](https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/global-visa-wait-times.html). (<https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/global-visa-wait-times.html>)

Remember that the DS-2019 does not guarantee a U.S. exchange visa. At your interview, you will be asked about your study plans, ties to your home country, future career objectives, and how you will fund your education in the U.S.

## ONLINE PRESENCE AND SOCIAL MEDIA REVIEW IN THE VISA APPLICATION PROCESS

Updated June 23, 2025

The U.S. Department of State (DoS) has announced expanded vetting of “online presence” for all F and J visa applicants, including students and exchange visitors. As part of this consular process, applicants are required to:

- Disclose all social media identifiers on the DS-160 visa application
- Set their social media profiles to “public” for consular review

Media reports based on a cable from the Secretary of State indicate that consular officers will be required to review applicants' online presence for "any indications of hostility towards the citizens, culture, government, institutions, or founding principles of the United States". Reports also state that that consular officers should flag "advocacy for, aid or support for foreign terrorists, and other threats to U.S. national security" and "support for unlawful antisemitic harassment or violence".

You can [review the DOS announcement here](https://www.state.gov/releases/office-of-the-spokesperson/2025/06/announcement-of-expanded-screening-and-vetting-for-visa-applicants/).  
(<https://www.state.gov/releases/office-of-the-spokesperson/2025/06/announcement-of-expanded-screening-and-vetting-for-visa-applicants/>)

## U.S. ADDRESS

If you do not have a U.S. address yet for the online non-immigrant visa application form (DS-160), you can use the Northeastern University address and phone number for your specific campus below:

**+ Click here for a list of Northeastern's U.S. Campus Addresses**

## OBTAINING A J-1 VISA

- If you are intending to attend Northeastern University, then you will need to use Northeastern's DS-2019 to pay the SEVIS fee and apply for a student visa.
- To obtain a student visa, the applicant must submit a valid DS-2019 form issued by Northeastern to the U.S. Embassy or U.S. Consulate in his/her country. Students are encouraged to apply for their visa as soon as they receive the DS-2019 to provide ample time for visa processing.
- Once students have received their J-1 visa, they are permitted to enter the U.S. 30 days in advance of the report date if they wish. In most countries, student visa applicants must appear in person for an interview. However, each U.S. Embassy and U.S. Consulate sets its own interview policies and procedures regarding

student visas, thus students should consult the embassy websites or call for specific application instructions.

- For the current listings of U.S. Embassies and U.S. Consulates abroad, we recommend the [following web link from the U.S. Department of State](#). (<https://www.usembassy.gov/>) Visit the U.S. Department of State website for the [latest information on visa processing, required material, visa applications and processing times](#). (<https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas.html>)

*NOTE: No assurances regarding the issuance of visas can be given in advance. Therefore, it is recommended that final travel plans or the purchase of nonrefundable tickets should not be made until a visa has been issued. After the visa is granted and processed, check your passport to be sure you received a J-1 visa stamp and that any dependents received J-2 visa stamps. Also, be certain that the original DS-2019 was returned to you, as you must have the original with you when you arrive to the U.S.*

## NECESSARY DOCUMENTS

**In general, international students may apply for a J-1 visa by presenting the following documents to the U.S. Embassy or U.S. Consulate:**

1. Certificate of Eligibility for nonimmigrant visa (DS-2019) issued by Northeastern University. Your assigned SEVIS identification number is in the upper right corner of the page. Check to see that all information is correct. NOTE: The spelling of your name and your date of birth must be exactly the same as what appears in your passport. Read the regulations governing J visa status on page 2 and sign and date the bottom of the page. Please read and sign the DS-2019 prior to presentation at the U.S. Embassy or U.S. Consulate.
2. Valid passport. Passport must be valid for at least six months after your proposed date of entry into the U.S.
3. Financial evidence that shows you have sufficient funds to cover your tuition (if applicable) and living expenses during the period you intend to study. At a minimum, you must prove you have sufficient funds for the length of your intended period of study as reflected on your DS-2019. If

you have more than one source of funding, please provide the required documentation corresponding to each source listed on the DS-2019 e.g.: personal or family funds, sponsorship letter, Northeastern award or scholarship letter, etc.

4. Proof of the SEVIS I-901 fee payment – see additional information below.
5. Admission letter from Northeastern University.
6. Complete the [Nonimmigrant Visa Electronic Application Form \(DS-160\)](https://ceac.state.gov/genniv/) (<https://ceac.state.gov/genniv/>). Visit the U.S. Department of State site for [Instructions](https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/forms/ds-160-online-nonimmigrant-visa-application.html) (<https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/forms/ds-160-online-nonimmigrant-visa-application.html>) and [Frequently Asked Questions](https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/forms/ds-160-online-nonimmigrant-visa-application/ds-160-faqs.html). (<https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/forms/ds-160-online-nonimmigrant-visa-application/ds-160-faqs.html>)
7. One photograph, [please read detailed information on photo requirements](https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/photos.html). (<https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/photos.html>)
8. Visa application fee: Check with the consulate for the fee amount and how it must be paid. This is separate from the SEVIS fee.

All applicants should be prepared to provide additional information, such as transcripts and diplomas from previously attended institutions, Test of English as a Foreign Language (TOEFL) and Scholastic Aptitude Test (SAT) scores, or documents which demonstrate the applicant intends to return home after his/her studies, etc.

## CITIZENS OF CANADA OR BERMUDA

Citizens of Canada or Bermuda do not need to apply for a J-1 student visa, **but they must have a DS-2019 and pay the SEVIS fee before entering the U.S.**

Upon the receipt of the DS-2019 from Northeastern, Canadian students may enter the U.S. by presenting the DS-2019, valid passport, the admission letter from Northeastern, evidence of financial support, and proof of SEVIS I-901 fee payment. The SEVIS fee cannot be paid at the port of entry.

## ADMISSION TO THE U.S.

J-1 student visa holders can seek admission to the U.S. up to 30 days prior to a program's report date as shown on the DS-2019. At the U.S. port of entry, you will be required to present your valid passport and the DS-2019 form to a representative of U.S. Customs and Border Protection. After reviewing all of required documents, a Customs and Border Protection officer will stamp your passport if admission is granted. An admission stamp will show the date of admission and class (J-1) of admission, and the duration of your stay. In most cases, the officer notes "Duration of Status" on the stamp. This means you are allowed to stay in the U.S. for the length of time indicated on your DS-2019 form, so long as you are maintaining full-time enrollment at the school that issued your DS-2019 form. Be sure that your passport is properly stamped before exiting the inspection area at a U.S. port of entry. For detailed information, please visit [U.S. Customs and Border Protection](https://www.cbp.gov/). (<https://www.cbp.gov/>)

## TWO YEAR HOME RESIDENCY REQUIREMENT (212E)

A J-1 exchange visitor may be subject to the "Two-Year Home Country Physical Presence Requirement." If the exchange visitor is subject to the two-year home-country physical presence (foreign residence) requirement, he or she cannot change his/her status to that of H, L, K, or immigrant lawful permanent resident until he or she has returned to his/her home country for at least two years or received a waiver of that requirement. To become subject to this requirement, one of the following criteria is met:

- > If you are financed in whole or in part by an agency of the U.S. government or by your home country's government
- > If your field of study is listed on a special "[Skills List](https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/study/exchange/waiver-of-the-exchange-)" (<https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/study/exchange/waiver-of-the-exchange->



[visitor/exchange-visitor-skills-list.html](#))” designated  
by the Exchange Visitor Program

Being subject to 212e does not impact your ability to return to the U.S. in the future as a tourist, on a visa waiver (such as ESTA), or in F or J status.

Please review your J-1 visa stamp in your passport and the DS-2019 you receive back from the U.S. Embassy Consulate to confirm whether you have been marked subject to 212e.

If a J-1 student believes they have been incorrectly subjected to the 212(e) per the reasons above, or the 212(e) information on the J-1 visa does not match the DS-2019, they should request an [advisory opinion](#) (<https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/visa-information-resources/advisory-opinions.html>) from the Department of State. *Please note: The Office of Global Services (OGS) is not able to directly assist or prepare documentation for this process.*

## RELATED ARTICLES:

Paying the I-901 SEVIS Fee

(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/new-students/paying-sevis-fee/>)

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Obtaining I-94

(<https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/new-students/arrival/obtaining-i-94/>)

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## CONTACT OGS

354 Richards Hall  
360 Huntington Avenue  
Boston, MA 02115  
+1-617-373-2310

[OGS Service Portal \(https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs\)](https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs)

## OFFICE HOURS

Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.-5:00p.m.

(Note: We are closed on Tuesdays from 3:00pm – 4:00pm for all staff training and meeting).

**Phone Hours:**

Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.–4:30p.m. ET

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